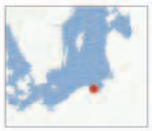
POLISH-SWEDISH WAR

OLIWA



Date November 28, 1627
Forces Swedish: 6 ships; Polish: 10 ships
Losses Swedish: 1 ship captured, 1 destroyed; Polish: none

Location Off Danzig (Gdansk), Poland

In 1627 Sweden was at war with the Polish-Lithuanian Commonwealth. In May the Swedish navy sent 15 ships to blockade the Polish port of Gdansk. Outbreaks of disease and wear and tear to the ships took its toll on the blockading squadron. By November only six ships were left on station. Poland had no naval tradition, but it had assembled a scratch naval force under the command of a Dutch merchant captain resident in Gdansk, Arend Dickmann. On November 28 Dickmann attacked the Swedish squadron with four galleons and six smaller vessels. His flagship *Sankt Georg* tackled the Swedish flagship *Tigern*. Swedish commander Nils Stjernskjold was killed; *Tigern* was captured. Another Swedish galleon, *Sol*, was blown up by her captain to avoid capture. The rest of the Swedish squadron fled. Dickmann, however, was killed, his legs shot away by a cannonball on Tigern's deck. It was the Polish navy's most famous victory.

THIRTY YEARS WAR

COLBERGER HEIDE



Date July 1, 1644
Forces Swedish: 34 ships; Danish: 40 ships
Losses none

Location Near Femern Island, off Germany

In 1644 Sweden and Denmark were on opposite sides in the Thirty Years War. A Swedish fleet under Finnish admiral Klas Fleming landed troops on the Danish island of Femern. Danish king Christian IV responded by leading a fleet out from Copenhagen. The Danes had more ships but were significantly outgunned by the Swedes. Fleming had the best of the initial manoeuvres. His flagship *Scepter* led an attack by several ships upon Danish admiral Jorgen Wind's *Patientia* heading the Danish van. King Christian's *Trefoldighed* came to Wind's aid but was also battered. The king suffered a head wound, which would cost him the sight of one eye, but stayed on deck. Wind was mortally injured and *Patientia* withdrew. Overall, however, the Danes had the better of the action, which ended with sunset. The badly mauled Swedish fleet was blockaded in Kiel Fjord for a month, during which time Fleming was killed.



Under fire
A Swedish man of war in the foreground exchanges fire with ships bearing the red Danish ensign. In the background more ships, possibly enemy reinforcements, approach to join the engagement.

SCANIAN WAR

ÖLAND

Date June 1, 1676
Forces Swedish: 26 ships of the line, 12 frigates; Dutch and Danish: 25 ships of the line, 10 frigates
Losses Swedish: 3 ships of the line, 4 other vessels; Dutch and Danish: none

Location Off Öland Island, the Baltic

The decision of Swedish king Charles XI to ally himself with French king Louis XIV in his struggle against the Dutch United Provinces eventually led to the Scanian War, in which the Dutch combined forces with Denmark against Sweden. Off Bornholm Island in late May 1676 a Danish and Dutch squadron under Danish admiral Niels Juel had the better of an encounter with a numerically superior Swedish force, which withdrew toward Stockholm. The allies were then reinforced by the arrival of nine ships under Dutch admiral Cornelis Tromp. Tromp immediately gave pursuit and caught up with the Swedes off the island of Öland. The Swedish commander, Admiral Lorens Creutz, was on board *Kronan*, one of the largest and most heavily armed warships of its day. The lower gun ports were opened on the flagship's leeward side as the Danish-Dutch fleet approached holding the weather gage. In a moment of confusion, Creutz ordered a sharp change of tack without reefing the sails. The open gun ports went under water as the ship heeled over. With sea pouring into the ship there was an explosion in the gunpowder store. *Kronan* sank rapidly, taking 801 of the 842 men on board to their deaths. Despite this catastrophe, some Swedish ships fought bravely. The 94-gun *Svärd* held out for two hours before striking its colors. After surrender she was hit by a Dutch fireship, causing a fire and explosion in which most of the 670 crew were killed. Scattered Swedish ships fleeing were pursued and a few captured. With this comprehensive defeat, Sweden decisively lost naval control of the Baltic.

SCANIAN WAR

KJÖGE BAY



Date July 1–2, 1677
Forces Swedish: 31 ships; Danish: 25 ships
Losses Swedish: 8 ships; Danish: none

Location Kjöge Bay, south of Copenhagen

In spring 1677 the Swedish navy sought to attack the Danes in the absence of their Dutch allies, who were slow to send ships to the Baltic that year. Danish admiral Niels Juel was also keen to fight in the absence of the Dutch, since the arrival of Admiral Cornelis Tromp would mean that he was superseded in overall command.

Juel deliberately offered the Swedes a chance to attack him in Kjöge Bay. The Swedish fleet was led by Henrik Horn, a field marshal who had no experience at sea. Juel unsurprisingly outmaneuvered him. On the morning of July 1 the Swedes attacked with the advantage of an offshore wind. The Danes skillfully fended off some Swedish fireships and then squeezed the Swedes against the coast. The 64-gun *Drake* ran aground at Stevns Point. Six Swedish ships remained behind to defend the exposed ship, while the rest broke for more open seas. *Drake* was forced to strike colors, lowering the ensign in surrender, while two of the ships left to protect her were also captured. Juel pursued the rest of the Swedish force and a fierce engagement ensued, during which the Danish admiral was forced to transfer his flag from the *Christianus V*.

The Dutch presented themselves for the second day of the battle and captured three Swedish ships, but the honor went to the Danish navy for their fine defeat of a numerically superior force.



Three victories
A medal commemorates Öland, Langeland, and Kjöge triumphs. The Swedish flagship is shown as she strikes her flag to the Danish.